

Tentative Rulings for May 19, 2026
Department 403

For any matter where an oral argument is requested and any party to the hearing desires a remote appearance, such request must be timely submitted to and approved by the hearing judge. In this department, the remote appearance will be conducted through Zoom. If approved, please provide the department's clerk a correct email address. (CRC 3.672, Fresno Sup.C. Local Rule 1.1.19)

There are no tentative rulings for the following cases. The hearing will go forward on these matters. If a person is under a court order to appear, he/she must do so. Otherwise, parties should appear unless they have notified the court that they will submit the matter without an appearance. (See California Rules of Court, rule 3.1304(c).) *The above rule also applies to cases listed in this "must appear" section.*

The court has continued the following cases. The deadlines for opposition and reply papers will remain the same as for the original hearing date.

25CECG04222 *Elvan Cruz Ortiz v. Sun Valley Raisins, Inc.* is continued to Tuesday, June 30, 2026, at 3:30 p.m. in Department 502.

(Tentative Rulings begin at the next page)

Tentative Rulings for Department 403

Begin at the next page

(20)

Tentative Ruling

Re: ***Perez v. Rosenbalm Rockery, Inc.***
Superior Court Case No. 24CECG00952

Hearing Date: May 19, 2026 (Dept. 403)

Motion: Plaintiffs' Motion for Preliminary Approval of Class Action Settlement

Tentative Ruling:

To grant.

**If oral argument is timely requested, it will be entertained on
Thursday, May 28, 2026, at 3:30 p.m. in Department 403.**

Explanation:

Certification of Class for Settlement

Settlements preceding class certification are scrutinized more carefully to make sure that absent class members' rights are adequately protected, although there is less scrutiny of manageability issues. (*Wershba v. Apple Computer, Inc.* (2001) 91 Cal.App.4th 224, 240; see *Dunk v. Ford Motor Co.* (1996) 48 Cal.App.4th 1794, 1803, fn. 9, 19.a) The trial court has a "fiduciary responsibility" as the guardian of the absentee class members' rights to decide whether to approve a settlement of a class action. (*Luckey v. Superior Court* (2014) 228 Cal.App.4th 81, 95.)

A precertification settlement may stipulate that a defined class be conditionally certified for settlement purposes. The court may make an order approving or denying certification of a provisional settlement class after the preliminary settlement hearing. (Cal. Rules of Court, rule 3.769(d).) Before the court may approve the settlement, however, the settlement class must satisfy the normal prerequisites for a class action. (*Amchem Products, Inc. v. Windsor* (1997) 521 US 591, 625-627.)

"Class certification requires proof (1) of a sufficiently numerous, ascertainable class, (2) of a well-defined community of interest, and (3) that certification will provide substantial benefits to litigants and the courts, i.e., that proceeding as a class is superior to other methods. In turn, the community of interest requirement embodies three factors: (1) predominant common questions of law or fact; (2) class representatives with claims or defenses typical of the class; and (3) class representatives who can adequately represent the class." (*In re Tobacco II Cases* (2009) 46 Cal.4th 298, 313.)

Plaintiffs bear the burden of establishing the propriety of class treatment *with admissible evidence*. (*Richmond v. Dart Industries, Inc.* (1981) 29 Cal.3d 462, 470 [trial court's ruling on certification supported by substantial evidence generally not disturbed on appeal]; *Lockheed Martin Corp. v. Superior Court, supra*, 29 Cal.4th at pp. 1107-1108 [plaintiff's burden to produce substantial evidence].)

There are approximately 137 class members ascertainable from defendant's business and payroll records. (Simonian Decl., ¶¶ 3, 4.) Numerosity and ascertainability are adequately established.

Under the community of interest requirement, the class representative must be able to represent the class adequately. (*Caro v. Procter & Gamble* (1993) 18 Cal.App.4th 644, 669.) "[I]t has never been the law in California that the class representative must have identical interests with the class members . . . The focus of the typicality requirement entails inquiry as to whether the plaintiff's individual circumstances are markedly different or whether the legal theory upon which the claims are based differ from that upon which the claims of the other class members will be based." (*Classen v. Weller* (1983) 145 Cal.App.3d 27, 46.)

Usually, in wage and hour class actions, the distinctive feature that permits class certification is that the employees have the same job title or perform similar jobs, and the employer treats all in that discrete group in the same allegedly unlawful fashion. In *Brinker Restaurant v. Superior Court* (2012) 53 Cal.4th 1004, 1017, "no evidence of common policies or means of proof was supplied, and the trial court therefore erred in certifying a subclass."

For settlement approval purposes, plaintiffs submit evidence that the class members are subject to common practices and policies, and experienced the same alleged wage and hour violations, and that plaintiffs have claims typical of the class. (See Simonian Decl., ¶ 5; Perez Decl., ¶¶ 4-5; Torres Decl., ¶¶ 4-5.)

The adequacy of representation component of the community of interest requirement for class certification comes into play when the party opposing certification brings forth evidence indicating widespread antagonism to the class suit. " 'The adequacy inquiry ... serves to uncover conflicts of interest between named parties and the class they seek to represent.' [Citation.] '... To assure "adequate" representation, the class representative's personal claim must not be inconsistent with the claims of other members of the class. [Citation.]' [Citation.]" (*J.P. Morgan & Co., Inc. v. Superior Court* (2003) 113 Cal.App.4th 195, 212.)

"[T]he adequacy inquiry should focus on the abilities of the class representative's counsel and the existence of conflicts between the representative and other class members." (*Caro v. Procter & Gamble Co.* (1993) 18 Cal.App.4th 644, 669.) This consideration is satisfied, as counsel has substantial class action experience.

Settlement Approval

"[I]n the final analysis it is the Court that bears the responsibility to ensure that the recovery represents a reasonable compromise, given the magnitude and apparent merit of the claims being released, discounted by the risks and expenses of attempting to establish and collect on those claims by pursuing litigation. The court has a fiduciary responsibility as guardians of the rights of the absentee class members when deciding whether to approve a settlement agreement." (*Kullar v. Foot Locker Retail, Inc.* (2008) 168 Cal.App.4th 116, 129.) "[T]o protect the interests of absent class members, the court

must independently and objectively analyze the evidence and circumstances before it in order to determine whether the settlement is in the best interests of those whose claims will be extinguished ... [therefore] the factual record must be before the ... court must be sufficiently developed." (*Id.* at p. 130.)

Clark v. America Residential Services (2009) 175 Cal.App.4th 785 vacated approval of a class settlement coupled with class certification, an award of \$25,000 each to two named plaintiffs, and more. The problem was that the plaintiffs presented "no evidence regarding the likelihood of success on any of the 10 causes of action, or the number of unpaid overtime hours estimated to have been worked by the class, or the average hourly rate of pay, or the number of meal periods and rest periods missed, or the value of minimum wage violations, and so on." (*Id.* at p. 793.)

Here, informal discovery and production of time and pay records occurred, which were analyzed by an expert, providing the basis for counsel's estimations of defendant's maximum potential exposure. Counsel provides an adequate discussion of the weaknesses and risks involved in taking the case through trial, sufficient to conclude that the proposed settlement is fair and reasonable.

The court can preliminarily approve the requested award of attorney's fees and costs. Plaintiffs' counsel seek \$141,667 in attorney fees, which is 1/3 of the total gross settlement, plus costs of up to \$40,000. 1/3 is within the range of fees that have been approved by other courts in class actions, which frequently approve fees based on a percentage of the common fund. (*City & County of San Francisco v. Sweet* (1995) 12 Cal.4th 105, 110-11; *Quinn v. State* (1975) 15 Cal.3d 162, 168; see also *Apple Computer, Inc. v. Superior Court* (2005) 126 Cal.App.4th 1253, 1270; *Lealao v. Beneficial California, Inc.* (2000) 82 Cal.App.4th 19, 26.)

While it is true that courts have found fee awards based on a percentage of the common fund are reasonable, the California Supreme Court has also found that the trial court has discretion to conduct a lodestar "cross-check" to double check the reasonableness of the requested fees. (*Laffitte v. Robert Half Intern. Inc.* (2016) 1 Cal.5th 480, 503-504 [although class counsel may obtain fees based on a percentage of the class settlement, courts may also perform a lodestar cross-check to ensure that the fees are reasonable in light of the number of hours worked and the attorneys' reasonable hourly rates].)

The court prefers to do a lodestar analysis as a cross-check on the reasonableness of the fees. Counsel provides preliminary information showing that their lodestar at this point totals \$99,855. The court finds the billing rates to be reasonable. With the final approval motion counsel will need to produce detailed billing records. While the court may award a lesser amount of fees on final approval, the information submitted is sufficient to preliminarily approve the requested fee award. The court will approve payment of only the actual costs incurred, which must also be documented.

In accordance with the order denying the last motion for preliminary approval, plaintiffs seek incentive awards of \$4,000 each. The court finds this to be reasonable and appropriate based on the plaintiffs' services to the class.

6

(37)

Tentative Ruling

Re: **Corral v. Webull Financial**
Superior Court Case No. 24CECG01122

Hearing Date: May 19, 2026 (Dept. 403)

Motion: By Defendant to Compel Plaintiff's Responses to Requests for Production and Special Interrogatories, to Deem Admissions Admitted, and for Monetary Sanctions

Tentative Ruling:

To deny. (Code Civ. Proc., §§ 1012-1013b.)

Oral argument on this matter is continued to June 3, 2026, at 3:30 in Dept. 403 so that the plaintiff may be present for oral argument via Zoom.

Explanation:

Service of the motions is defective. Defendant served plaintiff with the moving papers on February 13, 2026 at Pleasant Valley State Prison P.O. Box 8500 in Coalinga, California. *At that time*, the court's records indicate that service should have been at P.O. Box 3461 in Corcoran, California.

Defendant asserts that it propounded Special Interrogatories (Set One), Requests for Production (Set One), and Requests for Admissions (Set One) on plaintiff on December 23, 2025. Such were served at the Pleasant Valley State Prison P.O. Box 8500 in Coalinga, California. This mailing address is inconsistent with the mailing address the court had for plaintiff at the time the discovery was propounded. *At that time*, the court's records indicate that service should have been at P.O. Box 3461 in Corcoran, California.

Currently, the court's records indicate service should be made to plaintiff at California Men's Colony State Prison P.O. Box 8101 in San Luis Obispo, California.

The court's records do not reflect any email for plaintiff. As such, the court is not inclined to find email to satisfy service.

Pursuant to California Rules of Court, rule 3.1312(a), and Code of Civil Procedure section 1019.5, subdivision (a), no further written order is necessary. The minute order adopting this tentative ruling will serve as the order of the court and service by the clerk will constitute notice of the order.

Tentative Ruling

Issued By: Img on 5/18/26
(Judge's initials) (Date)

(35)

Tentative Ruling

Re: ***Tomik v. Albertsons Companies, Inc. et al.***
Superior Court Case No. 23CECG05182

Hearing Date: May 19, 2026 (Dept. 403)

Motion: By Defendants Albertsons Companies, Inc. and Madison Realty LLC for Leave to File Cross-Complaint

Tentative Ruling:

To grant. Defendants Albertsons Companies, Inc. and Madison Realty LLC shall serve and file their cross-complaint within 10 days of the date of service of this order.

**If oral argument is timely requested, it will be entertained on
Thursday, May 28, 2026, at 3:30 p.m. in Department 403.**

Explanation:

Defendants Albertsons Companies, Inc. and Madison Realty LLC (together "Defendants") seeks leave to file a cross-complaint to state a claim against cross-complainant Paynter Realty & Investments, Inc. and nonparty Citywide Property Services, Inc. (together "Proposed Cross-Defendants") for indemnity, apportionment, and declaratory relief, pursuant to Code of Civil Procedure section 426.50.

Defendants contend that they seeks to state a claim against Proposed Cross-Defendants for issues arising out of the same facts and incidents alleged by plaintiff Cindy Jean Tomik in the First Amended Complaint. As Defendants seek to state a claim against an existing party, related to the party's causes of action, the cross-complaint is compulsory. (Code Civ. Proc., § 426.30, subd. (a).)

Where a proposed cross-complaint is compulsory and seeks to state a claim against an existing party after the time to file an answer has passed, Code of Civil Procedure section 426.50 controls. Code of Civil Procedure section 426.50 states that:

A party who fails to plead a cause of action subject to the requirements of this article, whether through oversight, inadvertence, mistake, neglect, or other cause, may apply to the court for leave to amend his pleading, or to file a cross-complaint, to assert such cause at any time during the course of the action. The court, after notice to the adverse party, shall grant, upon such terms as may be just to the parties, leave to amend the pleading, or to file the cross-complaint, to assert such cause if the party who failed to plead the cause acted in good faith. This subdivision shall be liberally construed to avoid forfeiture of causes of action.

What constitutes good faith, or a lack of it under Code of Civil Procedure section 426.50 must be determined in light of and in conformity with great liberality. (Foot's

